Talent mobility

Zurich offers highest quality of living for international assignees according to Mercers 2024 Quality of Living city ranking

NEW YORK, December 3, 2024 — Mercer, a business of Marsh McLennan (NYSE: MMC) and a global leader in helping clients realize their investment objectives, shape the future of work and enhance health and retirement outcomes for their people, today released its 2024 Quality of Living city ranking, which assesses cities according to the practicalities of daily life for international assignees and their families.

Zurich has claimed the top spot in this year's ranking, followed closely by Vienna and Geneva in second and third place, respectively. Copenhagen once again takes the fourth spot, with Auckland rounding out the top five.

As organizations increasingly rely on international assignees to drive global business strategies, the quality of living in host cities becomes a key consideration that directly impacts these employees' allowances and compensation packages.

Yvonne Traber, Partner and Mercer's Global Mobility Leader, commented: "As cities face extreme weather, economic fluctuations and other challenges, the rankings provide valuable insights for HR leaders at multinational organizations to better navigate the complexities of global mobility management and enhance the overall experience for their international workforce."

Zurich rose to the top of the list due to its outstanding public services, low crime rates, lively cultural scene and commitment to sustainability. These factors, along with its goal in 2024 to enhance its airport connections and increase the number of flights to and from other continents, make it an ideal location for international assignees. However, Zurich is also ranked among the most expensive cities in the world due to its high housing costs, transportation expenses and the overall cost of goods and services.

"In an era of digital nomads and flexible working, Mercer's data shows that the most desirable destinations are those that blend a high quality of life and an affordable cost of living," continued Ms. Traber. "This presents a challenge for organizations and international assignees as they balance decisions related to relocation, investment and talent management."

Around the World

In Europe, Switzerland has four cities in the top 10 rankings, as Bern (9th overall) and Basel (10th overall) joined Zurich and Geneva at the top of the rankings this year. Eight out of the top 10 cities are located in western Europe, including Amsterdam (6th overall) and Frankfurt (7th overall), making it the most appealing region for international assignees.

Vancouver (7th overall) retains its spot as the highest-ranked city in North America this year, providing its residents a unique blend of outdoor recreation and cosmopolitan living. Boston (32nd overall) ranks first in the United States this year, beating out San Francisco, for its well-developed infrastructure and abundance of green spaces. Montevideo (92nd overall) is the top ranked city in Latin America again this year.

Auckland (5th overall) is the highest-ranked city in the Pacific once again. The city provides residents with a high standard of living, robust healthcare and a dynamic cultural scene. In Australia, Sydney secures 12th place with its world-renowned landmarks and thriving economy.

Dubai (83rd overall) and Abu Dhabi (85th overall) in the UAE once again lead the rankings in the Middle East, both known for their rapidly modernizing infrastructure and diverse international communities. Closely following, Port Louis (88th overall) is the top-ranked city in Africa.

First among Asian cities and 30th overall is Singapore, which offers a clean and safe environment combined with highly efficient infrastructure.

2024 Quality of Living Rankings

Ranking

1

City

Zurich

Location

Switzerland

Ranking

2

City

Vienna

Location

Austria

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Accetta

Rifiutare ciò che non è essenziale

Ranking

4

City

Copenhagen

Location

Denmark

Ranking

5

City

Auckland

Location

New Zealand

Ranking

6

City

Amsterdam

Location

Netherlands

Ranking

7*

City

Frankfurt

Location

Germany

Ranking

7*

City

Vancouver

Location

Canada

Ranking

9

City

Bern

Location

Switzerland

Ranking

10

City

Basel

Location

Switzerland

*Cities with the same ranking received the same Quality of Living score

About the 2024 Quality of Living Rankings

Mercer's Quality of Living research evaluates living conditions in more than 450 cities worldwide to help businesses calculate fair and consistent allowances for international assignees. Living conditions are analyzed according to 39 factors, grouped into 10 categories: political and social environment, economic environment, socio-cultural environment, medical and health considerations, schools and education, public services and transportation, recreation, consumer goods, housing and natural environment.

Data for the Quality of Living Rankings is analyzed annually and will be updated regularly to account for changing circumstances. All indices were calculated using New York City as the base city, due to its desirability and popularity for international assignees and its high scores across the 39 factors.

About Mercer

Mercer, a business of Marsh McLennan (NYSE: MMC), is a global leader in helping clients realize their investment objectives, shape the future of work and enhance health and retirement outcomes for their people. Marsh McLennan is a global leader in risk, strategy and people, advising clients in 130 countries across four businesses: Marsh, Guy Carpenter, Mercer and Oliver Wyman. With annual revenue of $23 billion and more than 85,000 colleagues, Marsh McLennan helps build the confidence to thrive through the power of perspective. For more information, visit mercer.com, or follow on LinkedIn and X.

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